ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

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CV, Interviews and Internships: Get Your First Real Opportunity

Turn a thin CV into a credible application and interview well with little experience

MONEY & CAREER

Money & Career

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Freshers often believe they have nothing to put on a CV. This pack shows how to convert coursework, volunteering and side projects into evidence of skill, structure a one-page CV, prepare for common interview questions and approach internships without waiting for third year.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Build a one-page CV with clear, evidence-based bullet points.
- Convert coursework and activities into demonstrable skills.
- Prepare answers for common interview questions using a structured method.
- Find and approach internship opportunities professionally.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

A CV that survives screening

A recruiter skims for relevance. Make the first screen easy.

- One page, clean layout, consistent formatting, no photograph unless requested.
- Order: contact, education, skills, experience and projects, leadership, references.
- Use action verbs and quantify where possible: 'organised five tutorials for 30 students'.
- Tailor the top third of the CV to the opportunity.
- Remove secondary-school details once you have university results.
- Check spelling of names, dates and contact details.

> **No experience is still experience**
> Course projects, volunteering, tutoring, a small business and committee roles all demonstrate reliability and skill. Describe what you did and the result.

Interview preparation

Preparation is visible. Practise in full sentences, not in your head.

- Prepare a two-minute introduction covering who you are, what you study and what you want.
- Use the situation-action-result structure for behavioural questions.
- Prepare examples for teamwork, conflict, failure and initiative.
- Research the organisation enough to ask one intelligent question.
- Prepare your own questions about the role and expectations.
- Dress appropriately, arrive early and switch off your phone.

Finding internships and attachments

Start earlier than the deadline and use more than one channel.

- Departmental industrial training coordinators and notice boards.
- Faculty and alumni networks; a warm introduction beats a cold email.
- Small firms and startups, which are often more accessible than large companies.
- Professional associations and student chapters.
- A short email stating what you study, what you can do and what you are asking for.
- Follow up once after a week; persistence done politely is not harassment.

A CV is evidence, not a biography

A recruiter spends under a minute on a first read. That means the top third of the page decides whether the rest is read. Put your name, contact details, degree and a two-line summary of what you offer at the top, and leave out the primary school you attended.

Write in outcomes rather than duties. "Organised a departmental career event attended by 120 students" is evidence; "helped with events" is not. Where numbers exist, use them. Where they do not, describe what changed because of you.

One page is enough for a student. Use a clean font, consistent dates, and reverse chronological order. Check for spelling and consistency - one error in a contact detail can end the application before the content is read.

Interviews: structure and the STAR method

Most graduate interviews combine a motivation question ("why this organisation?"), competency questions ("tell me about a time you led a team"), and a chance for you to ask questions. Prepare for the first two and use the third.

Answer competency questions with STAR: situation, task, action, result. Keep the situation brief, spend most of the answer on your action, and end on a concrete result. The commonest mistake is spending eighty per cent of the answer on context.

Research the organisation before you go: what it does, where it operates, and one recent development. Prepare two questions that show you have thought about the work, not about your own benefits. Arrive early, dress appropriately, and bring copies of your CV.

> **Prepare three stories**
> Three well-rehearsed stories - a team you led, a problem you solved, a failure you learned from - will answer most competency questions in some form.

Internships and first opportunities

Internships are found through three routes: advertised programmes with fixed application windows, personal and family networks, and direct approaches to organisations. The third is underused: a short, specific letter to a manager explaining what you can do and what you want to learn produces more offers than a hundred generic emails.

During an internship, reliability matters more than brilliance. Arrive on time, finish what you accept, ask questions after trying, and write down instructions. Most internships convert into references or offers for people who were dependable rather than exceptional.

At the end, ask for a written reference and a short conversation about what you should learn next. That conversation is worth more than the certificate.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Turning a role into a CV line

You were assistant secretary of a student society.

1. List what you actually did: minutes, correspondence, scheduling, records.
2. Find the outcomes: meetings held, members recruited, records organised.
3. Write a line with a verb, an object and a result.
4. Example: "Maintained minutes and correspondence for a 60-member society, reducing missed meetings by scheduling reminders a week ahead."
5. Remove any claim you cannot defend in an interview.
6. Place it under a heading such as Leadership and Organisation.

> **What to carry forward**
> Verb, object, outcome. If there is no outcome, find the change you produced.

2. Answering "tell me about a time you failed"

A standard question most candidates mishandle.

1. Choose a real failure with a real consequence, not a disguised strength.
2. Describe the situation briefly.
3. State your decision and why it was wrong.
4. Describe what you did to limit the damage.
5. State what you changed afterwards, with evidence.
6. Keep it under two minutes and end on the change.

> **What to carry forward**
> The answer is judged on what you changed, not on how interesting the failure was.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Explain the STAR method and why it suits competency-based interviews.

15 marks

1. Situation, task, action, result.
2. Competency questions ask for evidence of past behaviour.
3. STAR supplies evidence in a checkable structure.
4. Emphasise action and result over context.

Q2. What makes a student CV effective?

10 marks

1. One page, reverse chronological, consistent format.
2. Outcomes rather than duties.
3. Relevant evidence in the top third.
4. Accurate contact details and no errors.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

CV. A one to two page summary of education, experience and skills.

Competency question. A question asking for evidence of past behaviour.

STAR. Situation, task, action, result - a structure for behavioural answers.

Internship. A period of supervised work experience.

Reference. A statement about your performance from someone who supervised you.

Cover letter. A short letter explaining why you are applying for a specific role.

Assessment centre. A multi-exercise selection process.

Transferable skill. A capability usable across different roles.

Elevator pitch. A ninety-second account of who you are and what you offer.

Follow-up. A brief message after an interview thanking the panel.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - CV

Evidence.

- Draft a one-page CV.
- Convert three duties into outcomes.
- Have someone check it.

Week 2 - Stories

Interviews.

- Write three STAR stories.
- Rehearse each aloud under two minutes.
- Prepare two questions to ask.

Week 3 - Research

Targets.

- Research three organisations.
- Write one tailored cover letter.
- Send one direct approach.

Week 4 - Practise

Performance.

- Do a mock interview.
- Get feedback on pace and clarity.
- Ask one contact for a reference.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- A graduate careers guide covering CVs and interviews.
- Your university careers service materials.
- Your institution's internship and attachment policy.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. How should a CV bullet point be written?

Answer: Start with an action verb, state what you did and include a result or scale, for example 'managed a WhatsApp group of 120 students and increased assignment submission rates'.

2. What does the situation-action-result structure mean?

Answer: Describe the context, the action you took and the result achieved, so the interviewer can assess your behaviour.

3. Why tailor a CV for each application?

Answer: Screening looks for relevance; tailored documents show alignment with the specific role.

4. What should you include in an internship enquiry email?

Answer: Your course and level, relevant skills, the specific attachment you are requesting, dates and availability, and a polite request for consideration.

5. How should you follow up on an application?

Answer: Send one concise, polite message after about a week, restating your interest and availability.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write a one-page CV and have it reviewed by a senior colleague.
- [ ] List five skills with one concrete example each.
- [ ] Write your two-minute self-introduction.
- [ ] Prepare answers for three behavioural questions.
- [ ] Identify three organisations you can approach.
- [ ] Send one internship enquiry email.
- [ ] Practise a mock interview with a friend.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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